Deterrence in cyberspace is particularly problematic. The concept of deterrence is central to the nonconventional arena, as deterrence is the real force that prevents the use of nonconventional weapons, the result of which is disastrous. With nuclear weapons, deterrence is based on Mutually Assured Destruction (MAD), which means that when each side has second-strike capability, a regime of deterrence is in place.

The question is whether deterrence can be achieved in cyber warfare, given the fundamental difference between cyber warfare and other types of nonconventional warfare. The difference lies in the difficulty or inability to unambiguously identify the aggressor, combined with the inability to maintain deterrence based on second-strike capability.

Traditional deterrence is based on the fact that actors on both sides are identifiable. Moreover, they take care to identify themselves and enhance their capabilities in order to bolster deterrence (this applies more to nuclear capability and less to chemical and biological capabilities, though Saddam Hussein, for example, did declare his capabilities in this area publicly). When a party in a given conflict is the victim of a cyberattack and must respond, a key question it will face is that of the "smoking gun," meaning that the party is required to prove the identity of the attacker unequivocally before responding. Often the assailant may be an eighteen-year-old hacker in jeans and a T-shirt, carrying out the attack from his basement, which could be located literally anywhere on earth. And even if it is possible to pinpoint him, it is not always possible to know with certainty whether he is acting on his own behalf or at the request of a client, which could be a business, a criminal organization, a terrorist group, or a state.

The operational significance of this dialectic is that cyberspace, as an arena of military action, has a built-in tendency toward offense. It is possible that the strengthening of offensive capabilities and their disclosure will actually contribute to the establishment of a deterrence regime. True deterrence is possible only when one of the players has the proven ability to paralyze an entire country. In current reality, this is still hypothetical. Should it turn out that there is truth to the allegations that Russian hackers, acting in concert with the Russian authorities, carried out a cyberattack on the Democratic Party headquarters during the 2016 US presidential election campaign, we can imagine that this will serve as "raw material" to Americans planners formulating an entirely new kind of deterrence strategy, one that the world has not needed until now. It is not unreasonable to assume